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AI



# Perplexity sees India as a shortcut in its race against OpenAI

While OpenAI has cemented its lead in the U.S., Perplexity is taking a different route — quietly expanding into India to compete in the next phase of AI adoption. The search-focused AI startup is rapidly adding millions of users in the world's second-largest internet and smartphone market, positioning itself for mass-market scale.

This week, Perplexity [partnered with Bharti Airtel](#), India's second-largest telecom operator after Reliance Jio, to offer a free 12-month Perplexity Pro subscription — normally worth \$200 — to all 360 million Airtel subscribers. Airtel confirmed to TechCrunch that the deal is exclusive, meaning no other telco in the country can offer Perplexity's services, including free access, to their subscribers.

The Airtel partnership is one of Perplexity's most significant moves yet in a global expansion strategy that includes partnerships with more than 25 telcos globally, including those recently announced with [SoftBank in Japan](#) and [SK Telecom in South Korea](#). It comes down to volume. India, the world's most populous country, brings a mass market that the San Francisco-based startup will not find in other geographies.

Perplexity is already gaining major traction in the country. In Q2, Perplexity's downloads in India surged 600% year-over-year to 2.8 million, according to Sensor Tower data shared exclusively

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with TechCrunch. In comparison, OpenAI's ChatGPT saw a 587% increase, reaching 46.7 million downloads in the same period.

The growth trend extended to active users as well: Perplexity's monthly active users (MAUs) in India increased by 640% year-over-year in Q2, while ChatGPT's MAUs grew by 350%. India was also the largest market by MAUs for Perplexity in the last quarter, per Sensor Tower. However, ChatGPT maintained a significant lead in absolute numbers, with 19.8 million MAUs versus 3.7 million for Perplexity.

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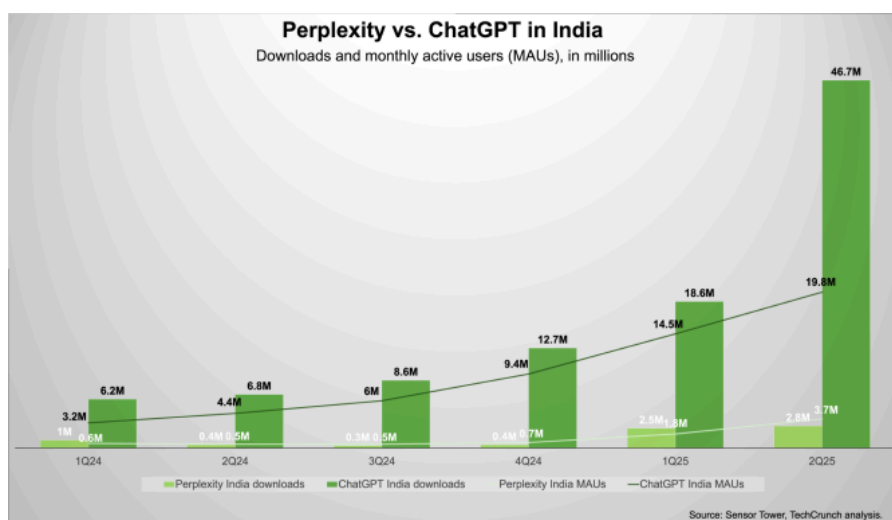


IMAGE CREDITS: JAGMEET SINGH / TECHCRUNCH

Building on earlier partnerships, Perplexity has been working to leverage India's user base to leapfrog Western markets, where OpenAI dominates paid subscribers. Earlier this year, Perplexity [partnered](#) with the Indian fintech giant Paytm to offer access to its AI-powered search through the Paytm app, which has over 500 million downloads and is among the [top-three apps on the Indian government's Unified Payments Interface](#) network, processing over 1.2 billion transactions worth over ₹1,34,000 crores (approximately \$15.6 billion).

Perplexity CEO Aravind Srinivas has also taken direct steps to expand in India. In January, he announced [plans to hire an Indian executive](#) in the

country, which he later put on hold after receiving an [“overwhelming” response](#). He further [announced a \\$1 million investment](#) and a commitment of five hours a week of his time to a group building AI in India.



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India vs. Global Perplexity downloads  
(in millions)

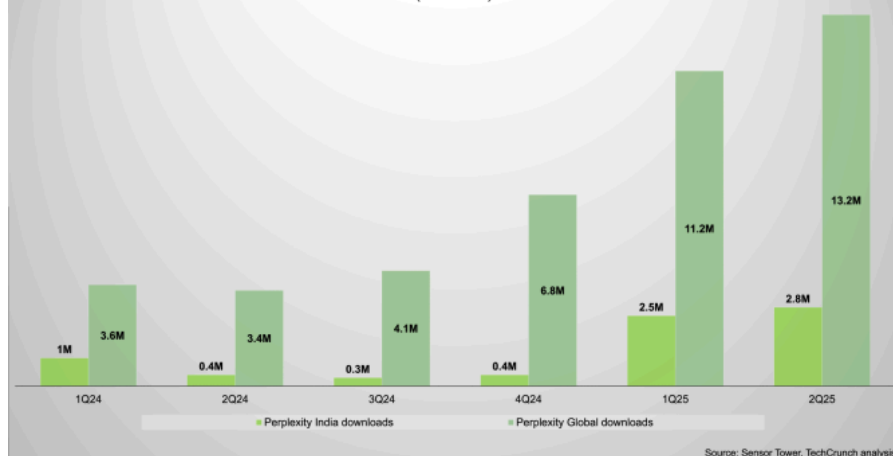


IMAGE CREDITS: JAGMEET SINGH / TECHCRUNCH

The startup has also internally discussed offering its AI search engine to Indian students to grow its reach, sources told TechCrunch.

One reason Perplexity views India as a key growth market is the relatively [limited number of local AI startups](#), particularly in the AI search space. At the same time, the country has a large and active base of tech-savvy users — a fact that has even prompted Perplexity’s archrival Google to launch AI-powered search features like [AI Mode](#) and [AI Overviews](#) in India ahead of many other markets.

Monetizing that large user base remains a challenge. Perplexity still lags far behind ChatGPT globally in terms of revenue, even as both offer the same \$20-per-month starting price. In Q2, ChatGPT’s in-app purchase revenue worldwide surged 731% year-over-year to \$773 million, while Perplexity saw a 300% increase, reaching \$8 million, per Sensor Tower.

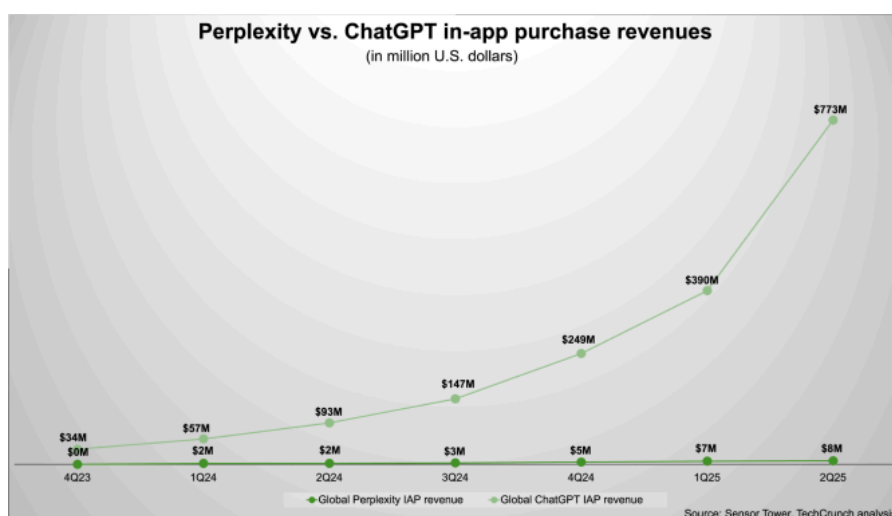


IMAGE CREDITS: JAGMEET SINGH / TECHCRUNCH

The revenue challenge is particularly acute in India, where consumers are notoriously [price-sensitive](#). Still, there are promising signs. ChatGPT saw an 800% year-over-year increase in in-app purchases to \$9 million in the country in Q2. Perplexity has not generated any notable in-app revenue from India, but the startup has room to expand its paid subscriber base through India. Deals like the one with Airtel could help Perplexity effectively increase its subscriber base, at least in the short term.

Strategic partnerships in markets like India could help Perplexity catch the eye of investors who value user growth and geographic diversification. But to turn that attention into long-term backing, the startup will need to show that it can convert its expanding user base into revenue.

Srinivas did not respond to requests for comment.

Topics: [AI](#) [Airtel](#) [ChatGPT](#) [India](#) [OpenAI](#)

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Jagmeet covers startups, tech policy-related updates, and all other major tech-centric developments from India for...

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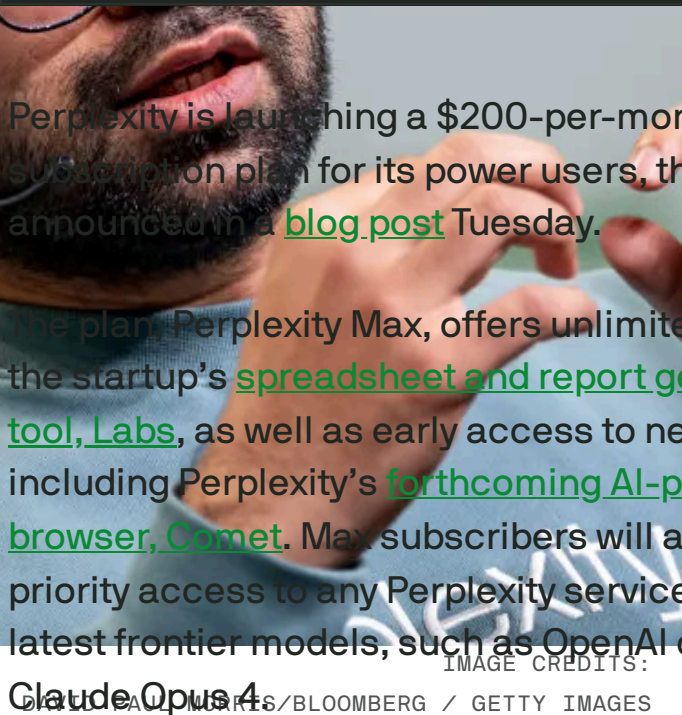
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Perplexity is launching a \$200-per-month subscription plan for its power users, the company announced in a [blog post](#) Tuesday.

The plan, Perplexity Max, offers unlimited access to the startup's [spreadsheet and report generation tool](#), [Labs](#), as well as early access to new features, including Perplexity's [forthcoming AI-powered browser, Comet](#). Max subscribers will also get priority access to any Perplexity services using the latest frontier models, such as OpenAI o3-pro and Claude Opus 4.

IMAGE CREDITS:

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With the launch of Max, Perplexity became the latest AI provider to offer a hyper-premium subscription tier to capitalize on its power users. OpenAI was the first to do so with its [\\$200-a-month ChatGPT Pro subscription](#), but [Google](#), [Anthropic](#), and [Cursor](#) have followed suit in recent months.

Perplexity now offers a variety of subscription plans. Alongside the \$200-a-month Max plan, Perplexity offers a consumer Pro plan for \$20 a month, as well as an Enterprise Pro plan that costs \$40 a month per person. The startup says it will eventually offer a hyper-premium Max plan for Enterprise customers as well.

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In 2024, Perplexity generated roughly \$34 million in revenue largely driven by subscriptions to its \$20-a-month Pro plan, but still burned about \$65 million in cash, according to financials seen by [The Information](#). Most of Perplexity's cash burn reportedly comes down to heavy spending on cloud servers and buying access to AI models from OpenAI and Anthropic.

Perplexity's business seems to have grown since last year — it reportedly [had an ARR of \\$80 million in January](#). However, the startup needs to generate significantly more revenue to justify its valuation. In May, Perplexity held [late-stage talks to raise \\$500 million at a \\$14 billion valuation](#). It's unclear if that round officially closed.

But Perplexity's competition in the AI search market is intensifying. In recent months, Google has heavily pushed [AI Mode](#), its own AI-powered search product, which bears a striking resemblance to Perplexity's app, in front of its users. OpenAI has also integrated search more deeply into ChatGPT in recent months and has reportedly [considered launching a browser of its own](#).

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One key to Perplexity’s success may be its ability to work with AI providers, which it relies on for AI models, while simultaneously beating them in the AI search market. The added revenue from Perplexity Max subscribers could bolster the startup’s ability to compete in the space.

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**Maxwell Zeff**

Senior AI Reporter |

Maxwell Zeff is a senior reporter at TechCrunch specializing in AI. Previously with Gizmodo, Bloomberg,...

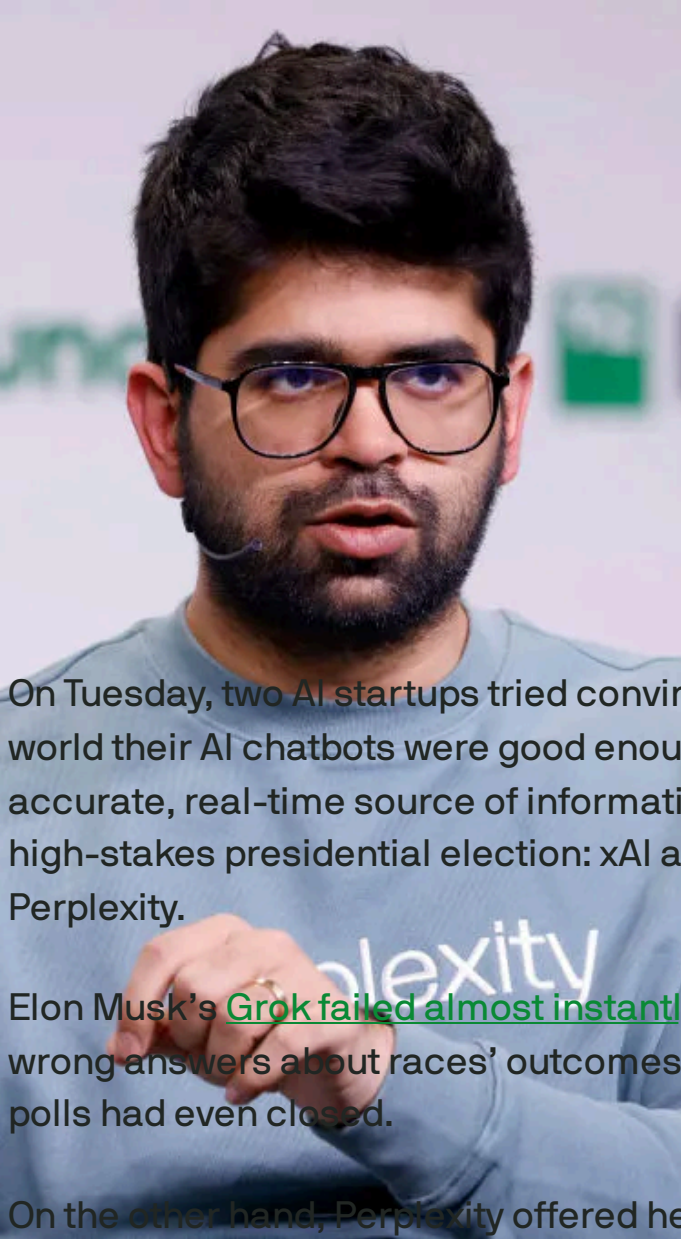
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The other election night  
winner: Perplexity



Maxwell Zeff — 11:54 AM PST · November 6, 2024

On Tuesday, two AI startups tried convincing the world their AI chatbots were good enough to be an accurate, real-time source of information during a high-stakes presidential election: xAI and Perplexity.

Elon Musk's [Grok failed almost instantly](#), offering wrong answers about races' outcomes before the polls had even closed.

On the other hand, Perplexity offered helpful, real-time election insights and maps throughout the night, linking to reliable resources and offering historical context where appropriate.

Perplexity took a risky bet, and it paid off.

Late last week, the startup announced [the launch of its election information hub](#), featuring real-time maps populated with voting data from Democracy Works and the Associated Press, the same information sources that power Google's election map. This approach was different from most other AI chatbots, such as OpenAI's ChatGPT or Google's Gemini, which simply refused to answer questions related to the election.

It's understandable why most AI labs sat this election out. It was the safe and responsible choice for many of them, as they've been plagued by

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[embarrassing hallucinations](#) at some point or another in the last year.

In particular, OpenAI [recently released its Google competitor, ChatGPT Search](#). But the Sam Altman-led startup didn't trust the feature to answer questions about this election, directing users to Vote.org instead. ChatGPT Search is still an early product, which is [too unreliable for people to use in everyday scenarios](#), and OpenAI seems to have recognized that.

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In contrast, Perplexity has been testing its Google competitor out in the real world since December 2022 and clearly felt it had enough data to give this election a shot.

Perplexity's election night success could set it back in its [ongoing fight with media companies](#); specifically, Dow Jones' recent lawsuit claiming the startup competes with media companies for the same audiences. Despite the many outbound links within the AI chatbot's answers, Perplexity's

election hub was itself a destination on election night, and it didn't require users to venture off the app to get all their information. It certainly seems like Perplexity was competing with media companies, who were also vying for eyeballs on election night, even though Perplexity collects its information from those outlets. Perplexity CEO Aravind Srinivas even [claimed](#) "record traffic" the day before and clearly hoped to maintain that momentum.

While Perplexity had deals with Democracy Works, the AP, and a few other media companies to power election features, the startup also indiscriminately used live election coverage from other media outlets such as CBS, CNN, and the BBC. Sure, Perplexity offered attribution, but the company hasn't announced any revenue-sharing partnerships with these outlets and it's unclear if any money changed hands.

## How Perplexity fared on Election Night

First, let's start with Perplexity's election features that had nothing to do with generative AI: the charts.

People typically love visual election charts, clicking into them and seeing granular data on a state-by-state level. It was a smart move for Perplexity to build these out and ensured their AI systems were not the sole source of information in the app.

# U.S. General Election 2024

Voter Guide

President

Senate

House



Kamala Harris

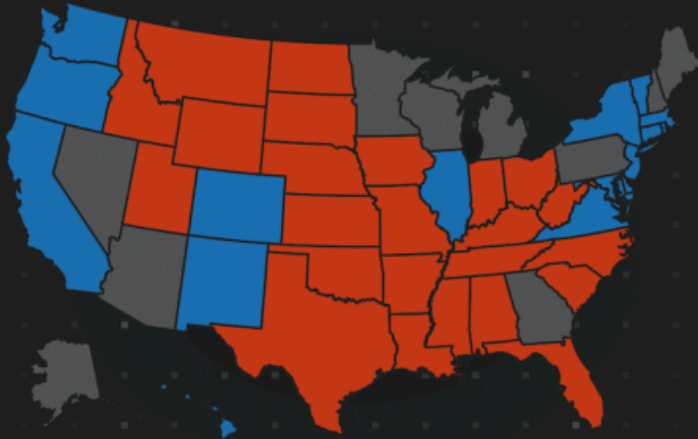
Donald Trump



210

270 ELECTORAL VOTES TO WIN

230



DC

Updating Live

perplexity



SCREENSHOT OF PERPLEXITY'S ELECTION HUB AT 9:14 PM PT ON NOV. 5.

IMAGE CREDITS:MAXWELL ZEFF/PERPLEXITY

When visiting Perplexity's election hub, users were met with a familiar-looking electoral map of the United States, with some states blue for Kamala Harris and others red for Donald Trump. Obviously, Perplexity didn't reinvent the wheel with this feature — copying the display Google and every TV network shows — but they didn't need to. Throughout the night, this map appeared to update every minute or so, reflecting the information on the Associated Press' website. It was a good way to follow the election.

There were bugs in Perplexity's map periodically throughout the night. Srinivas [responded to users on X](#) that were reporting flaws, such as Perplexity not reporting the percentage of votes that had been counted, and quickly addressed them.

SWING STATE TRACKER IN PERPLEXITY'S ELECTION HUB.

IMAGE CREDITS:MAXWELL ZEFF/PERPLEXITY

Perplexity offered another familiar feature, a state-by-state tracker, giving real-time information about swing states.

Now for the AI part. When asked questions about the current state of the presidential race, Perplexity answered with hedged responses that still gave mostly accurate information. These answers weren't as insightful as a commentator on CNN, nor as entertaining as The New York Times' election needle (which made a comeback this year). However, Perplexity only showed a few small hallucinations and largely produced relevant facts in a timely manner. That's more than I can say for any other AI chatbot on the market.

|                           |                            |
|---------------------------|----------------------------|
| PROMPT ON ELECTION NIGHT. | PERPLEXITY'S ANSWER AROUND |
| IMAGE CREDITS:MAXWELL     | 9:15 PM PT ON NOV. 5.      |
| ZEFF/PERPLEXITY           | IMAGE CREDITS:MAXWELL      |
|                           | ZEFF/PERPLEXITY            |

When trying to answer follow-up questions about Harris' lead in "Blue Wall" states, Perplexity did hallucinate slightly. It was referencing polling data, when it should have been referencing real-time votes at this point in the night. However, the general information here was in the right ballpark, and other AI chatbots just wouldn't answer this question.

|                                     |                       |
|-------------------------------------|-----------------------|
| FOLLOW-UP PROMPT ON ELECTION NIGHT. | IMAGE CREDITS:MAXWELL |
| IMAGE CREDITS:MAXWELL               | ZEFF/PERPLEXITY       |
| ZEFF/PERPLEXITY                     |                       |

Here's another follow-up question we tried: What ballots have yet to be counted in swing states? It was hard to find an answer to this question

elsewhere. Granted, the only useful answers here were for Pennsylvania and North Carolina, but at least Perplexity didn't hallucinate for the other states.

FOLLOW-UP PROMPT ON ELECTION NIGHT.

IMAGE CREDITS:MAXWELL ZEFF/PERPLEXITY

PERPLEXITY'S ANSWER AROUND 9:20 PM PT ON NOV. 5.

IMAGE CREDITS:MAXWELL ZEFF/PERPLEXITY

This election was the first to feature AI chatbots as a source of information around our democratic processes. However, this will not be the last election where that's the case. Well-funded AI startups are fighting to deliver information to people in new, faster, more concise ways. Accuracy will be key to success here moving forward. So far, Perplexity has the early lead.

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